

Aggie ACHIEVE

Certificate in Interdisciplinary Studies

Overview

Aggie ACHIEVE (Academic Courses in Higher Inclusive Education and Vocational Experiences) at Texas A&M University is a four-year postsecondary opportunity for young adults with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) who have exited high school. Prospective students apply to Texas A&M University through an alternate admissions process in which they are evaluated by an Admissions Committee designated by Aggie ACHIEVE. Aggie ACHIEVE provides an inclusive and immersive college education and equips students for employment in the community. Aggie ACHIEVE aligns coursework, internship opportunities, and extracurricular activities with each student's academic interests and employment goals. Aggie ACHIEVE students reside in Texas A&M residence halls and have access to all campus-related activities.

Aggie ACHIEVE is housed within the Department of Educational Psychology in the College of Education and Human Development. Aggie ACHIEVE is also affiliated with the Center on Disability and Development, a nationally recognized University Center of Excellence on Developmental Disabilities (UCEDD).

Students who attend Aggie ACHIEVE will have access to campus and community life similar to that of their peers on campus. They have the opportunity to:

- Participate in the equivalent of five hours of inclusive TAMU coursework per semester, including courses related to academics, physical education, and orientation to college,
- Pursue active membership in clubs and student organizations,
- Participate in orientation events and campus programs, and
- Develop lifelong relationships with faculty, staff, and peers on campus.

Each student's program of study is individually designed through a comprehensive, collaborative process called person-centered planning, where each student and their family member(s) meet with a staff member to design individualized goals. Faculty will work with ACHIEVE staff to develop a modified syllabus and Independent Learning Agreement to set expectations and assignments.

In the first two years, students are introduced to college life through weekly seminars focused on independent living, career awareness, and self-determination. Beginning in the spring of their first year, students will participate in on-campus internships for approximately 3-5 hours each week to prepare for inclusive employment. The last two years focus on career development and field specialization, including opportunities for off-campus paid internships in a student's field of interest.

Goals of Aggie ACHIEVE

The overarching purpose of Aggie ACHIEVE is to assist young adults in reaching their postschool outcomes. Aggie ACHIEVE consists of three overarching goals:

1. Develop a four-year post-secondary pathway for students with IDD in Texas.
2. Enable students to have an immersive and inclusive college experience in which they have access to all services and supports available to any TAMU student.
3. Assist students in reaching their post-school goals in the areas of competitive employment and independent living.

Transforming the future of Aggie ACHIEVE students also means expanding opportunities and experiences of our TAMU students already on campus. Aggie ACHIEVE has the ability to improve attitudes and create opportunities of growth for those who will go on to key corporate, community, and civic leadership roles around the country after graduation.

Academic Courses

Each student will have the opportunity to participate in one TAMU undergraduate course per semester. These classes are among peers without disabilities. Course selection will be based on faculty availability, student interest, and family input. Aggie ACHIEVE staff will work with each TAMU professor to modify syllabi and assignments to meet each student's individual needs. Students will attend class with a peer mentor who will assist them during class and in completing assignments. Courses will be graded based on satisfactory or unsatisfactory (i.e., pass/fail).

Independent Learning Agreements

Independent Learning Agreements (ILA) will be used to set academic goals with the professor of the class and to receive feedback on course performance. Prior to each semester, students will meet individually with the course instructor and the Aggie ACHIEVE program director to review expectations of the class and set learning goals for the semester. Following the end of the semester, the course instructor will provide feedback on the student's performance based on the ILA. The program director will be available for ongoing support for students and faculty should a need for revisions to the ILA arise during the semester.

First Year Experience

The Office for Student Success at Texas A&M University offers a year-long, first-year experience course designed to orient all freshmen and transfer students to college life and campus resources. During their first year, Aggie ACHIEVE students will participate in one weekly zero-credit course with the faculty director, two peer mentors, and up to 20 other freshmen.

Physical Education Activity Program

Aggie ACHIEVE students will also have the opportunity to register for one Physical Education Activity Program (PEAP) course per semester. PEAP courses are offered as one-credit courses. PEAP has a vast amount of sporting and physical activity options such as basketball, dance, swimming, and weight lifting. Students will be able to choose which course they would like to take each semester.

Seminars

Students will participate in at least two seminars per semester with the program director and graduate assistant. Seminars are a great way for students to continue to work on transition skills but more in-depth and in relation to living on a college campus. Seminars may include financial management, self-determination and advocacy, career awareness/readiness, technology, job shadowing, health and wellness, interpersonal skills, and decision making.

Employment Internships

Students will have the opportunity to participate in employment internships with various departments on campus and businesses in the community to offer hands-on employment experiences in inclusive settings. Employment internships will be based on the student's preferences, strengths, interests, and needs.

Starting in the second semester of their first year (beginning spring 2020), students will register for one internship course per semester. These courses are offered as one-credit courses. For the first two years of the program, internships will be located on-campus. These internship settings will be selected based on students' interests and may include the libraries, dining halls, restaurants, or recreational centers. During the last two years, students will have the opportunity to venture off-campus to work in a setting more directly aligned with their chosen field of specialization. In preparation for the final year of the program, students will work closely with the Job Developer to identify relevant, inclusive employment opportunities locally or in their hometown.

Admission Requirements

Prospective students for Aggie ACHIEVE must meet the following criteria:

- i. Completed high school and no longer receiving support from the school.
- ii. Documented disability diagnosis of intellectual disability; received special education services in high school with an IEP
- iii. Demonstrate ability to communicate (not limited to verbal speech) reliably with staff, faculty, and mentors.
- iv. Demonstrate ability to live independently and take care of daily functioning and basic support needs (e.g., toileting, hygiene, feeding, etc.)
- v. Demonstrate at least 3rd grade reading level in comprehension and fluency.

- vi. Demonstrate ability to function independently for a sustained period of time (e.g., able to sit through 90-minute courses and function independently for 1-hour blocks of time, including navigating campus independently)
- vii. Demonstrate basic mathematics understanding and ability to use a calculator.
- viii. Express desire and motivation to complete a postsecondary education program.
- ix. Express desire to attain a job in an inclusive employment setting upon completing the program.
- x. Demonstrate active participation throughout the application and interview process.
- xi. Demonstrate sufficient emotional and independent stability to participate in all aspects of the Aggie ACHIEVE coursework and campus environment.
- xii. Be able to handle and adapt to change; not overly stressed when schedules or people change.
- xiii. Have proof of health insurance (Medicaid, Medicare, private).
- xiv. Serve as own guardian.
- xv. Must be able to independently self-administer and manage medication and specialized dietary needs.
- xvi. Demonstrate the ability to navigate campus safely (e.g., crossing streets and parking lots independently).

Preferred qualifications:

- i. Between the age of 18 and 27 at the time of entry into the program.

Fee Description

Aggie ACHIEVE is supported by private philanthropy and student fees.

\$20,500 support fees and Texas A&M fees:

Designated Tuition: \$891

University Advancement Fee: \$515

Health Center Fee: \$75

Rec Sports Fee: \$106

Student Center Fee: \$100

Aggie ACHIEVE Fee: \$8,563

Program of Study

Aggie ACHIEVE's Certificate in Interdisciplinary Studies includes seven TAMU courses, six-credits of Physical Education Activity Program (PEAP), seven-credits of internship, and six seminar courses.

Certificate of Interdisciplinary Studies: 13-credit bearing courses

Required Texas A&M University Courses (Inclusive): Zero-Credit

- UGST 181: First Year Seminar
- Must pick at least one of the following courses:
 - INST 301: Educational Psychology
 - INST 210: Understanding Special Populations

- Complete at least five additional TAMU elective courses based on student's interests and coordination with instructors/faculty (*approved by the program director*). Potential courses are:
 - ANSC 117: Texas BBQ
 - ENTO 322: Insects in Human Society
 - EPFB 210: Family Involvement and Empowerment
 - THAR 281: Theatre History II
 - BIMS 125: Animals in Society

See advisor for list of electives

Required Physical Education Activity Program (PEAP) (Inclusive): 6-Credits

- At least 6-credits of KINE 199: Required Physical Activity (1-credit each)

Required Employment Internships (Inclusive): 7-Credits

- At least 4-credits of EPSY 284: Employment Internship (1-credit each)
 - 1-credit can be substituted with EPSY 289
- At least 3-credits of UGST 484: Internship (1-credit each)

Required Seminar Courses (Aggie ACHIEVE specific): Non-credit bearing

Seminars will be held twice a week and are specific to Aggie ACHIEVE. Seminars are designed to provide more in-depth instruction related to academic courses, employment, and independent living. Aggie ACHIEVEMates can also participate in these classes. Seminars are program specific. Therefore, they are not formal classes at Texas A&M and students do have to register for them.

First Year:

Fall: Navigating College Life

Spring: Health and Wellness

Second Year:

Seminars will be offered each semester and will be based on the needs of the students in each cohort. Below are several examples of possible seminar classes:

- Financial Management
- Technology
- Career Awareness
- Career Exploration
- Self-Determination and Advocacy
- Interpersonal Skills and Decision Making
- Independent Living

Third and Fourth Years:

The third and fourth years of Aggie ACHIEVE are highly individualized; focusing heavily on employment-related skills. Therefore, students do not take seminar classes during

their third or fourth year in Aggie ACHIEVE but instead work individually with staff on areas in which they need more instruction.

Clocked Hours by Year

Year One:

Year one weekly total average 39 to 47 hours

Fall Semester: Equivalent to 8 credit hours

- TAMU non-credit bearing course hours- 8 average weekly hours
- Physical Education Activity Program credit-bearing course- 4 average weekly hours
- Aggie ACHIEVE seminar- 4 average weekly hours
- Study Hall (including academic tutors)- 6 average weekly hours
- Planning sessions with peer mentors - 2 average weekly hours
- Campus life (including lunch/dinner and wellness/exercise)- 10 to 12 average weekly hours
- Extracurricular activities and student organizations- 3 to 4 average weekly hours
- Program meetings/weekly check-ins - 2 average weekly hours

Spring Semester: Equivalent to 10 to 11 credit hours

- TAMU non-credit bearing course hours- 8 average weekly hours
- Physical Education Activity Program credit-bearing course- 4 average weekly hours
- Aggie ACHIEVE seminar- 4 average weekly hours
- Employment Internships- 3 to 5 average weekly hours
- Study Hall (including academic tutors)- 6 average weekly hours
- Planning sessions- 2 average weekly hours
- Campus life (including lunch/dinner and wellness/exercise)- 10 to 12 average weekly hours
- Extracurricular activities and student organizations- 3 to 4 average weekly hours
- Program meetings/weekly check-ins - 2 average weekly hours

Year Two:

Year two weekly total average 45 to 52 hours

Fall Semester: Equivalent to 9 to 11 credit hours

- TAMU non-credit bearing course hours- 4 average weekly hours
- Physical Education Activity Program credit-bearing course- 4 average weekly hours
- Aggie ACHIEVE seminar- 4 average weekly hours
- Employment Internships- 6 to 10 average weekly hours
- Study Hall (including academic tutors)- 6 average weekly hours
- Planning sessions- 2 average weekly hours
- Job Development- 4 average weekly hours
- Campus life (including lunch/dinner and wellness/exercise)- 10 to 12 average weekly hours
- Extracurricular activities and student organizations- 3 to 4 average weekly hours
- Program meetings/weekly check-ins - 2 average weekly hours

Spring Semester: *Equivalent to 9 to 11 credit hours*

- TAMU non-credit bearing course hours- 4 average weekly hours
- Physical Education Activity Program credit-bearing course- 4 average weekly hours
- Aggie ACHIEVE seminar- 4 average weekly hours
- Employment Internships- 6 to 10 average weekly hours
- Study Hall (including academic tutors)- 6 average weekly hours
- Planning sessions- 2 average weekly hours
- Job Development- 4 average weekly hours
- Campus life (including lunch/dinner and wellness/exercise)- 10 to 12 average weekly hours
- Extracurricular activities and student organizations- 3 to 4 average weekly hours
- Program meetings/weekly check-ins - 2 average weekly hours

Year Three:

Year three weekly total average 42 to 50 hours

Fall Semester: *Equivalent to 8 to 9 credit hours*

- TAMU non-credit bearing course hours- 4 average weekly hours
- Physical Education Activity Program credit-bearing course- 4 average weekly hours
- Employment Internships- 7 to 10 average weekly hours
- Study Hall (including academic tutors)- 6 average weekly hours
- Planning sessions- 2 average weekly hours
- Job Development- 4 to 6 average weekly hours
- Campus life (including lunch/dinner and wellness/exercise)- 10 to 12 average weekly hours
- Extracurricular activities and organizations- 3 to 4 average weekly hours
- Program meetings/weekly check-ins - 2 average weekly hours

Spring Semester: *Equivalent to 8 to 9 credit hours*

- TAMU non-credit bearing course hours- 4 average weekly hours
- Physical Education Activity Program credit-bearing course- 4 average weekly hours
- Employment Internships- 7 to 10 average weekly hours
- Study Hall (including academic tutors)- 6 average weekly hours
- Planning sessions- 2 average weekly hours
- Job Development- 4 to 6 average weekly hours
- Campus life (including lunch/dinner and wellness/exercise)- 10 to 12 average weekly hours
- Extracurricular activities and student organizations- 3 to 4 average weekly hours
- Program meetings/weekly check-ins - 2 average weekly hours

Year Four:

Year four weekly total average 36 to 44 hours

Fall Semester: *Equivalent to 10 to 12 credit hours*

- TAMU non-credit bearing course hours- 4 average weekly hours

- Employment Internships- 15 to 20 average weekly hours
- Study Hall (including academic tutors)- 4 average weekly hours
- Planning sessions- 2 average weekly hours
- Job Development- 8 to 10 average weekly hours
- Extracurricular activities and student organizations- 3 to 4 average weekly hours

Spring Semester: *Equivalent to 10 to 12 credit hours*

- TAMU non-credit bearing course hours- 4 average weekly hours
- Employment Internships- 15 to 20 average weekly hours
- Study Hall (including academic tutors)- 4 average weekly hours
- Planning sessions- 2 average weekly hours
- Job Development- 8 to 10 average weekly hours
- Extracurricular activities and student organizations- 3 to 4 average weekly hours